

ENTRY MANAGEMENT

ABOUT THE DEALS

You may be either Opener or Responder, but you will always be in the South position.

You are asked to study the Deal and mentally devise a Plan to make the contract.

ENTRY MANAGEMENT LESSON

There may be nothing more frustrating in Bridge than looking across at dummy and seeing three good tricks sitting there - and you have no way to reach them.

Entry Management may sound classy, but it just means being in the right place at the right time.

Plan Early and Wisely:

The contract is 3NT and West leads the ♠7.

♠ A 8 3 2

♥ A J 6 4

♦ A Q 5 3

♣ A



♠ K 6

♥ 7 5 3

♦ 6 4 2

♣ K Q J 10 3

If you play low from dummy you will be forced to win your ♠K immediately, or at trick 2 after East wins trick 1 and returns another ♠.

Now you will go down because after unblocking dummy's ♣A you have no entry back to your hand.

You may have planned early, but you didn't play wisely. The contract is absolutely cold as long as you win the first trick with dummy's ♠A. Then you unblock the ♣A and you still have the ♠K entry to your hand.

Simple enough, right? Just use common sense and think **before** you play, not after.

And the good news is that most of the entry problems you encounter will be just that easy to solve.

But there are a few tougher cases, and a few strategies to get around them, which is why you decided to read this lesson.

Cheap Tricks, and when not to take them:

Bridge players realize early that it is obviously a good idea to win a trick with the smallest card that they can, thereby keeping their higher cards for later. It's hard to ignore that principle, even when you should.

Here's another 3NT contract. (Yes, Bridge writers love to use 3NT contracts.)

West leads the ♠3. East plays a low ♠.

♠ Q J 10
 ♥ 7 3
 ♦ K J 10 9 8
 ♣ 8 6 4

Suppose you let dummy's ♠10 win the trick.

When you try to establish the ♦ suit East will take the second ♦ and return a ♠.

If you play low from your hand West will take the ♠A and play another ♠ to your ♠K.

You will never reach dummy's good ♦s.

♠ K 7 5
 ♥ A Q 3 2
 ♦ Q 5
 ♣ A K 7 2

If instead you play your ♠K when East leads that second ♠ West will allow your ♠K to hold the trick.

You will never reach dummy's good ♦s.

It is easy to now see where things went wrong.

Get your ♠K out of the way by using it to win the first trick and dummy's ♠ Q J will guarantee an entry to the ♦ suit.

Unblocking intermediate cards:

Sometimes a hand looks so simple that you don't spot the danger until too late.

The contract is 6NT. West leads the ♠6.

East takes the ♠A and returns the ♠J.

♠ 5 3 2
 ♥ 6 2
 ♦ 8 5 4
 ♣ A K Q 5 3

This looks like a cinch as long as the ♣s don't split 4-0.

You win the second trick with your ♠K, play the ♣4 to dummy's ♣Q, and breathe a sigh of relief when both defenders follow suit (it turns out they split 3-1).

♠ K 7 4
 ♥ A K Q
 ♦ A K Q
 ♣ 8 7 6 4

A few minutes later that sigh of relief turns into a cry of anguish when you discover that you can only win 4 ♣ tricks because after taking ♣ A K Q you will take the next ♣ in your hand!

Try it again from trick 2. This time play the ♣8 to dummy's ♣Q, and play the ♣7 and ♣6 under the ♣K and ♣A. Then, when you play dummy's ♣5 you can slip your ♣4 underneath it!

Overtaking to save an entry:

There is another way the sacrifice of a high card may pay off as an entry.

The contract is 3NT. West leads the ♠Q.

♠ 6
 ♥ 8 4 3
 ♦ A Q 10 9 8 7
 ♣ K 5



♠ A K 4 2
 ♥ A 7 6 2
 ♦ K
 ♣ A 8 6 4

Outside the ♦ suit you have 5 winners and no chance of creating any more.

So you need to get at least 4 ♦ tricks.

Suppose you win the first trick, play your ♦K, then go to dummy with the ♣K and start running the ♦s. All will be well if they split 3-3 but a 4-2 split is more likely with one defender holding ♦ J x x x.

Now try it this way. Win the first trick, play your ♦K, **OVERTAKE IT WITH THE ♦A**, then continue with ♦Q, ♦10. Somebody will win their ♦J but you still have that precious ♣K dummy entry to those other good ♦s.

The ♦K was worth more as an entry than it was as a high card.

Finessing for an entry:

That title doesn't sound like much of a daring strategy - of course there are times when you will have to finesse to get the entry you need.

Ahh, but here we are talking about a finesse that would otherwise be completely unnecessary, one which, if it loses, will actually throw a sure trick away.

The contract is 6♣. West leads the ♥Q.

♠ K Q 9 7 6 3
 ♥ 6 4 2
 ♦ A J
 ♣ 4 2



♠ --
 ♥ A K 5 3
 ♦ K 8
 ♣ A K Q J 9 8 7

You have 2 ♥ losers. A 3-3 split in the suit would allow you to set up your fourth ♥ but West's opening lead makes you think he probably has 4 or 5 ♥s.

You decide you must establish some ♠ tricks in dummy, but you need two entries for that play, one to get over there the first time and the second to get back after you have dislodged their ♠A. Unfortunately you have only one sure entry, the ♦A.

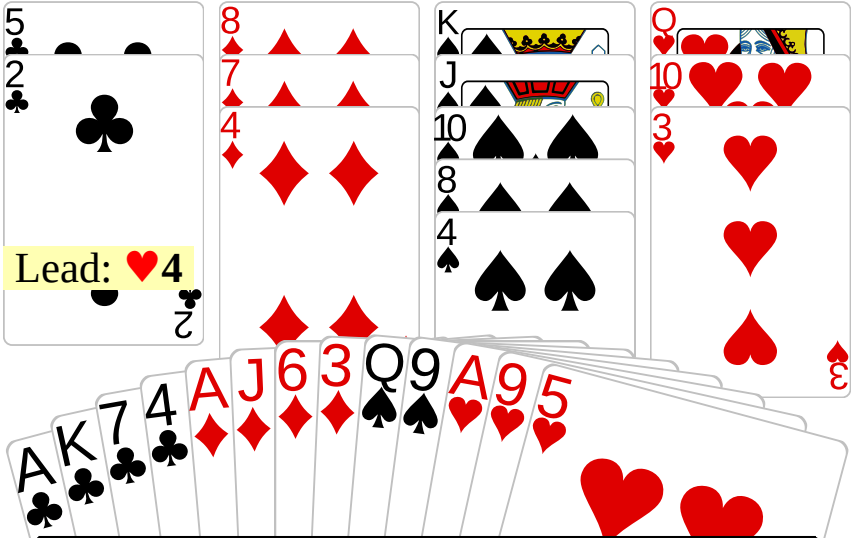
Win the first trick. Pull trumps in 2 or 3 rounds. Play a small ♦ and when West plays low finesse the ♦J - the unnecessary finesse. Today it wins. Now play the ♠K and when East plays a low card discard a ♥ loser. West can win the ♠A but you win his return, enter dummy with the ♦A and discard your other ♥ loser on the ♠Q.

Now ask yourself this: How good would West have to be to put his ♦Q on your first ♦ play to deprive you of that entry? Pretty good, I'd say.

There are other scenarios, many involving the sacrifice of a winner to gain an entry, and while we could go on and on and on . . .

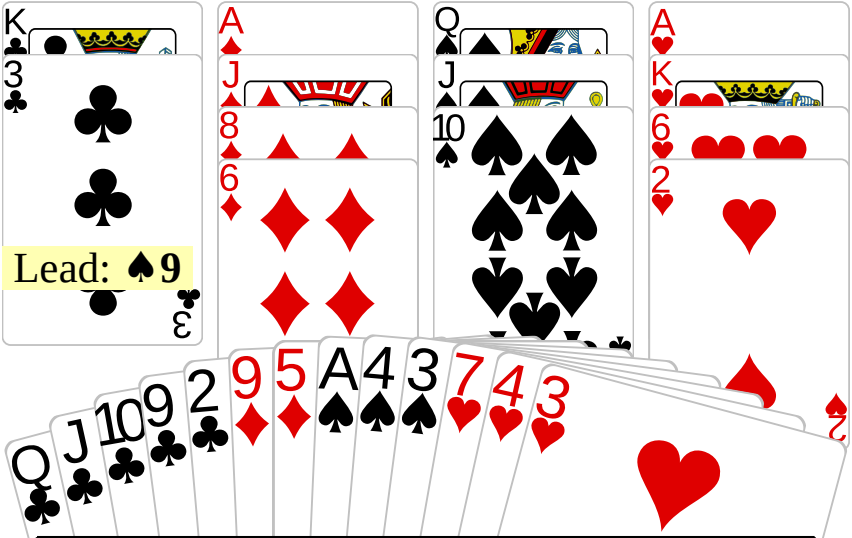
. . . 20 examples should be worth more than another 2000 words.

Deal 1 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners



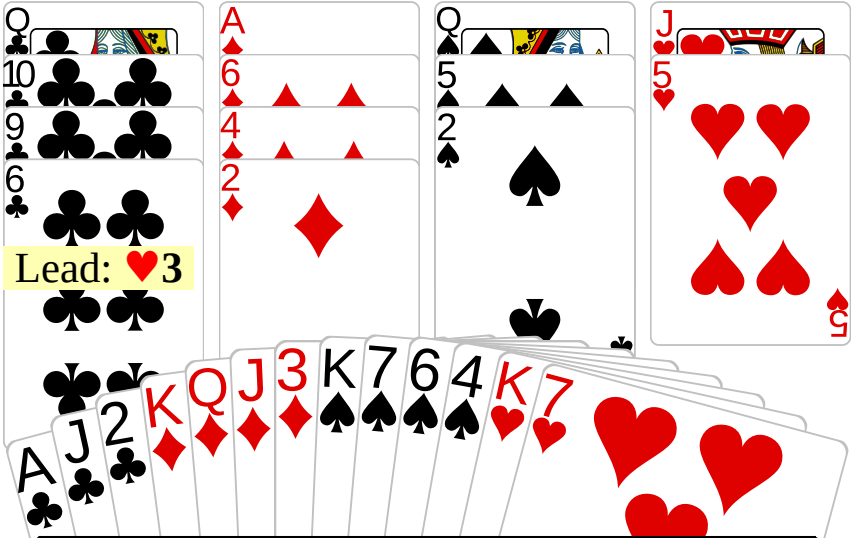
Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 2 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners



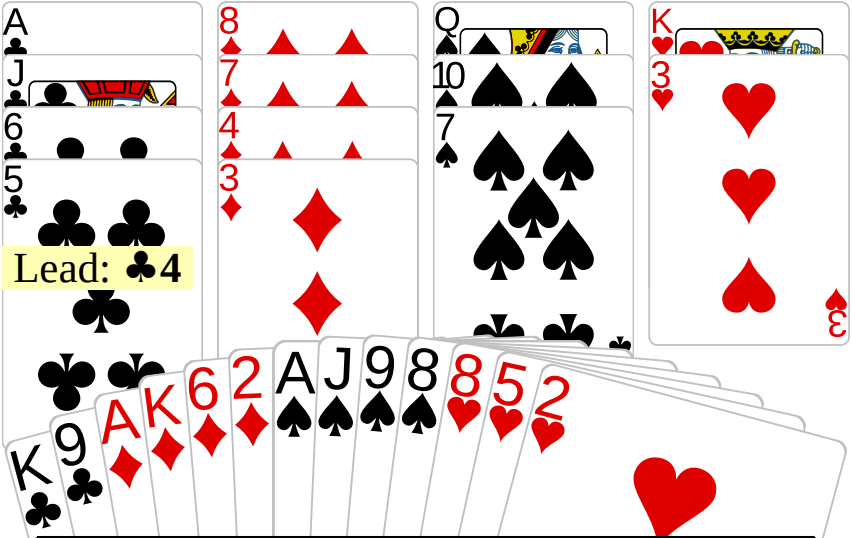
Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 3 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners



Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 4 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners



Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 5 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners

8♣

7♣

6♣

4♣

Lead: ♠Q

10♦

6♦

4♦

4♠

K♥

Q♥

J♥

10♥

3♥

Q♣

J♣

2♣

A♦

K♦

J♦

5♦

3♦

2♦

A♠

K♠

6♠

A♥

Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 6 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners

K♣

10♣

5♣

Lead: ♦2

A♦

K♦

Q♦

6♦

K♠

A♥

K♥

7♥

5♥

3♥

A♣

J♣

3♣

8♦

5♦

4♦

Q♠

J♠

10♠

9♠

3♠

6♥

2♥

Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**
Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥4

Board: 2
Dealer: **West**
Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♠9

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**
Contract: 3NT
Declarer: South
Lead: ♥3

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**
Contract: 3NT
Declarer: West
Lead: ♣4

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**
Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♠Q

Board: 6
Dealer: **West**
Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♦2

Board 1

North Deals

None Vul

♠ A 7 5 2

♥ 8 6

♦ K 9 5 2

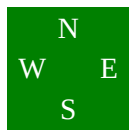
♣ Q J 6

♠ Q 9

♥ A 9 5

♦ A J 6 3

♣ A K 7 4



♠ 6 3

♥ K J 7 4 2

♦ Q 10

♣ 10 9 8 3

♠ K J 10 8 4

♥ Q 10 3

♦ 8 7 4

♣ 5 2

West

North

East

South

1♦

Pass

1♠

Pass

2NT

Pass

3NT

All Pass

3NT by North

Lead: ♥4

dummy and the rest of the ♠s by leading toward the ♥Q.

On these pages there have been many deals where you had to win the opening lead with an unnecessarily high card in order to create a later entry to dummy.

Here's a question: How many times at the table have situations like this presented themselves but you didn't realize it? And of course, at the table there is no second page popping up to tell you what you should have done.

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♥4, you play low in dummy and West plays the ♥8.

Winners: ♠=0 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=2 Total = 5

The winners list looks a little skimpy, but what a nice solid ♠ suit. It will be a cinch to establish 4 winners in the suit - if only you have an entry to reach them.

You are probably getting good at this by now. The way to make sure of a dummy entry is to pass up the Cheap Trick ♥9 and win the first trick with the ♥A. Since West did not play third-hand-high he probably doesn't have a high card to play. You are confident that East has led from the ♥K so by taking the ♥A at once you guarantee you can get back to dummy when you need to do so.

After you win the ♥A you start on ♠s, and they hold-up their ♠A for one round. But you can get to

Board 2

West Deals

N-S Vul

♠ Q J 10
 ♥ A K 6 2
 ♦ A J 8 6
 ♣ K 3

♠ K 2

♥ J 10 9 5

♦ Q 7 4 2

♣ A 7 5

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ A 4 3

♥ 7 4 3

♦ 9 5

♣ Q J 10 9 2

♠ 9 8 7 6 5

♥ Q 8

♦ K 10 3

♣ 8 6 4

West

1 ♦

2NT

All Pass

3NT by East

Lead: ♠9

North

Pass

Pass

East

1NT

3NT

South

Pass

East is to play 3NT. South leads the ♠9, and North plays the ♠K.

Winners: ♠=3 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=0 Total = 6

I'll bet you got this one. The extra ♣ tricks you need are winnable only if you can get back to your hand after knocking out the ♣A. But the only possible entry card is the ♠A. If you use it on the first trick the Defense will hold up their ♣A for one trick and your hand will be shot..

So let North keep the first trick, (sacrificing one ♠ winner), and take the next ♠ in dummy. Then establish ♣s.

You sacrifice one ♠ trick for four ♣ tricks. A good deal.

Yet another variation on the theme.

There are two basic types; one where you give up a winner to gain an entry, and this type where you get the entry without giving up a thing.

It looks a little different, but the theme is the same. PROTECT YOUR ENTRY.

Board 3

South Deals

None Vul

♠ J 9
♥ A 10 8 3 2
♦ 9 7 5
♣ 8 5 4

♠ Q 5 2

♥ J 5

♦ A 6 4 2

♣ Q 10 9 6

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ A 10 8 3

♥ Q 9 6 4

♦ 10 8

♣ K 7 3

♠ K 7 6 4

♥ K 7

♦ K Q J 3

♣ A J 2

West	North	East	South
			1NT
Pass	2NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			
3NT by South			
Lead: ♥3			

So win the ♥K and play the ♦ K Q. If both defenders follow suit you can afford to overtake your ♦J with dummy's ♦A. Now play the ♣10 and let it ride. If it holds the trick play another ♣ to your ♣J and then play the ♣A, dropping East's ♣K.

Enter dummy by playing your ♦3 to the ♦6 and take your established ♣ for the ninth trick.

Suppose a defender showed out on the second ♦.

With only one outside entry to dummy your choices are limited.

You might play East for ♣ K x and lead a small to your ♣J, then play ♣A.

Or you might try leading the ♣Q hoping that East will see this as a time to "cover an honor with an honor".

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♥3, you play dummy's ♥J and East plays the ♥Q.

Winners: ♠=0 ♥=1 ♦=4 ♣=1 Total = 6

Unless you want to go down really, really early you had better take your ♥K right now. And unless you want to go down almost as early you'd better stay completely away from the ♠ suit. So that only leaves you the ♣ suit to get 3 more winners in. East will have to have ♣K so you can finesse it. You are also going to have to be smart with entries. Got it?

If East has just ♣ K x then one finesse, followed by the ♣A to drop the ♣K and a small ♣ back to dummy will give you the 4 ♣ winners you must have. But if East has ♣ K x x and refuses to cover then you will be able to establish the ♣s but will need an extra dummy entry to enjoy that last winner.

Board 4

West Deals

Both Vul

♠ A J 9 8
♥ 8 5 2
♦ A K 6 2
♣ K 9

♠ 6 4
♥ 9 7 6 4
♦ Q 9 5
♣ Q 10 8 4

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ Q 10 7
♥ K 3
♦ 8 7 4 3
♣ A J 6 5

♠ K 5 3 2
♥ A Q J 10
♦ J 10
♣ 7 3 2

<i>West</i>	<i>North</i>	<i>East</i>	<i>South</i>
1NT	Pass	3NT	
All Pass			
3NT by West			
Lead: ♣4			

if not covered. Finally, one last ♠ finesse gives you 4 ♠ winners.

West is to play 3NT. North leads the ♣4, you play dummy's ♣5 and South plays the ♣7.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=0 ♦=2 ♣=3 Total = 6

You'd really like to find 3 winners without broaching that ♥ suit, so you decide to pin your hopes on the ♠ finesse. But you have a problem. When you win the first trick with the ♣9 your only safe entry to dummy is by leading your ♣K to the ♣A. And this uses up one of your ♣ winners! Do you see a way to avoid the problem?

Don't win the first trick with the ♣9, win with the ♣K. Then at trick two enter dummy by playing your ♣9 and finessing the ♣J! You are pretty sure North has led from the ♣Q so you expect this to work. Then play the ♠10, underplaying your ♠8. You had better cash the ♣A next, then the ♠Q, letting it ride

This is another twist on the them of winning with a higher card than necessary.

Here it doesn't actually create an extra entry, it just preserves the one entry you have but saves you an actual trick.

Here is an interesting point. Suppose that North's opening lead had been a ♥ and South had taken the first four ♥ tricks then played a ♦. You would have played the hand the same way! Take the ♣K, then finesse the ♣J.

Board 5

North Deals

N-S Vul

♠ 8 5 3
 ♥ 8 6 5 2
 ♦ Q 9 7
 ♣ A 10 5

♠ A K 6

♥ A

♦ A K J 5 3 2

♣ Q J 2



♠ Q J 10 9 7 2
 ♥ 9 7 4
 ♦ 8
 ♣ K 9 3

♠ 4

♥ K Q J 10 3

♦ 10 6 4

♣ 8 7 6 4

West	North	East	South
	2♣	Pass	2♦
Pass	3♦	Pass	3♥
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			
3NT by North			
Lead: ♠Q			

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♠Q.

Winners: ♠=2 ♥=1 ♦=2 ♣=0 Total = 5

There they are, four perfectly good ♥ tricks and no straightforward way to reach them. On the other hand, (I should say "In the other hand"), you have the possibility of 6 ♦ tricks, if the ♦Q drops, in which case you won't need the ♥ tricks at all. Can you work those two possibilities into a strategy?

Sure. The ♦ problem is that the outstanding ♦s may split 3-1 with one defender holding ♦Q x x. So it would appear you could only get 5 ♦ winners. But you can thwart him like this.

Win the ♠. Unblock the ♥A. Now play the ♦J. If Mr. ♦Q x x takes this trick dummy's ♦10 will become an entry to those wonderful ♥s. But if he cleverly refuses to win the ♦Q, then it will fall under your ♦A K and you will get all 6 ♦ tricks.

The biggest problem with this great play is that West probably doesn't know for sure what you are doing to him.

Maybe after the hand is over he will appreciate it more and congratulate you.

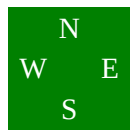
Board 6

West Deals

E-W Vul

♠ K
 ♥ A K 7 5 3
 ♦ A K Q 6
 ♣ K 10 5

♠ A 6 2
 ♥ Q J 9 4
 ♦ 10 3
 ♣ 9 7 6 2



♠ Q J 10 9 3
 ♥ 6 2
 ♦ 8 5 4
 ♣ A J 3

♠ 8 7 5 4
 ♥ 10 8
 ♦ J 9 7 2
 ♣ Q 8 4

West	North	East	South
2 ♣	Pass	2 ♠	Pass
3 ♥	Pass	3NT	
All Pass			

3NT by East

Lead: ♦ 2

pass it to South. If South takes the ♣Q then you will have TWO entries to your hand, one to get there for a ♠ lead, and the other to reach the ♠ winners after you have driven out the ♠A. But if South DOESN'T take the ♣Q, or if North actually has it, then you will have 3 ♣ tricks and your contract.

Isn't it nice to have a finesse that wins if it wins but also wins if it loses?

East is to play 3NT. South leads the ♦ 2.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=2 ♦=3 ♣=2 Total = 8

The reason the Winners list shows 1 ♠ is that the defenders are going to have to let you win dummy's ♠K. If they take that then you'll have 4 ♠ winners in your hand!

So you only need one more winner really, and if you guess the ♣ finesse right you will have it. Which way will you finesse, and why?

You will finesse through North. If he has the ♣Q you will win all 3 ♣ tricks, but if South has the ♣Q you may win even more. Just watch.

Win the opening ♦ lead in dummy. Play the ♠K which the defenders are not about to take while you have a ♣ entry to your hand. Now play the ♣10 and